among diverse people, cultures and ideologies. Scientists who discover a new pathogen may develop a vaccine to protect people. But if the scientists – or their political overlords – believe in a racist ideology that advocates that some races are inferior and should be exterminated, the new medical knowledge might be used to develop a biological weapon that kills millions.

In this case, too, the naive view of information holds that additional information offers at least a partial remedy. The naive view thinks that disagreements about values turn out on closer inspection to be the fault of either the lack of information or deliberate disinformation. According to this view, racists are ill-informed people who just don't know the facts of biology and history. They think that 'race' is a valid biological category, and they have been brainwashed by bogus conspiracy theories. The remedy to racism is therefore to provide people with more biological and historical facts. It may take time, but in a free market of information sooner or later truth will prevail.

The naive view is of course more nuanced and thoughtful than can be explained in a few paragraphs, but its core tenet is that information is an essentially good thing, and the more we have of it, the better. Given enough information and enough time, we are bound to discover the truth about things ranging from viral infections to racist biases, thereby developing not only our power but also the wisdom necessary to use that power well.

This naive view justifies the pursuit of ever more powerful information technologies and has been the semiofficial ideology of the computer age and the internet. In June 1989, a few months before the fall of the Berlin Wall and of the Iron Curtain, Ronald Reagan declared that 'the Goliath of totalitarian control will rapidly be brought down by the David of the microchip' and that 'the biggest of Big Brothers is increasingly helpless against communications technology … Information is the oxygen of the modern age … It seeps through the walls topped with barbed wire. It wafts across the electrified, booby-trapped borders. Breezes of electronic beams blow through the Iron Curtain as if it was lace.'[2] In November 2009, Barack Obama spoke in the same spirit on a visit to Shanghai, telling his Chinese hosts, 'I am a big believer in technology and I'm a big believer in openness when it comes to the flow of information. I think that the more freely information flows, the stronger the society becomes.'[3]

Entrepreneurs and corporations have often expressed similarly rosy views of information technology. Already in 1858 an editorial in *The New*